

Arthritis Flare-Ups — How to Recognise, Manage, and Recover

Learn how to spot the early signs of an arthritis flare, what to do when one hits, the role of medication, and how to prevent future flare-ups.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Pending clinical review ·
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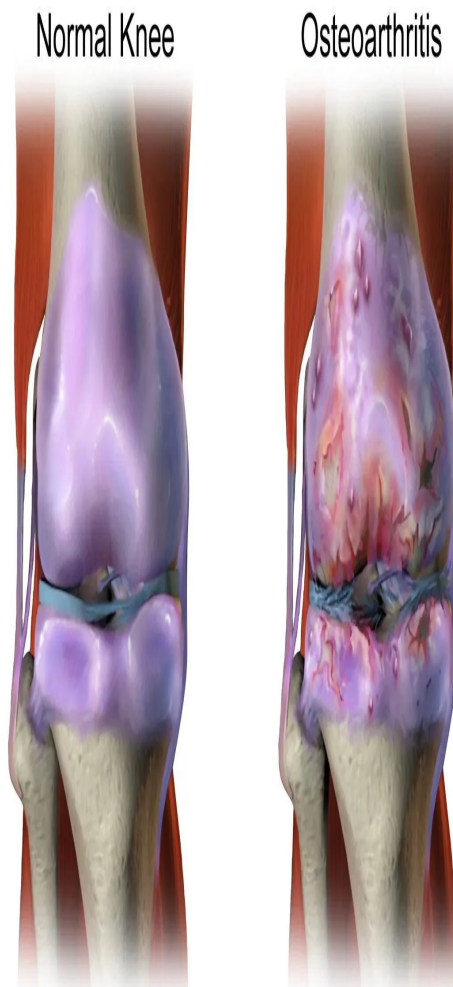
One day you feel steady. The next, your joints are swollen, stiff, and screaming — as if all your progress has been undone overnight. If this sounds familiar, you have experienced an arthritis flare-up. Flare-ups are frightening and frustrating. But they are also part of living with arthritis — and they can be managed. This guide will help you recognise a flare early, take the right steps when it happens, and reduce the chance of future flares.

What Is an Arthritis Flare-Up?

A flare-up (or "flare") is a sudden, temporary worsening of your arthritis symptoms. Instead of your usual background pain, you experience a spike that may last anywhere from a few days to several weeks. Flare-ups happen in all types of arthritis, but they feel different depending on your diagnosis:

- **Osteoarthritis (OA) flares:** Often triggered by overuse or injury. Pain increases and the joint may swell. Typically settles within days to a week with rest.
 - **Rheumatoid arthritis (RA) flares:** Involve increased inflammation — joints become hot, red, swollen, and stiff (especially in the morning). Can last longer and may need medication changes.
 - **Gout flares:** A specific type of flare caused by urate crystals in the joint. Extremely painful and sudden, often affecting the big toe.
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Early Warning Signs of a Flare



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Your body often gives you clues before a full flare hits. Learning to spot these warning signs can help you act early:

- Increased stiffness — especially in the morning, lasting longer than usual
- Fatigue — unusual tiredness, feeling "drained"
- Mild swelling or warmth — a joint that feels warmer or puffier than yesterday
- "Foggy" feeling — trouble concentrating (common in RA flares)
- Mood changes — feeling low or irritable for no clear reason
- Reduced range of motion — a joint that does not bend or straighten as far as usual

If you notice these signs, it is time to ease up on activity and focus on self-care — before the flare worsens.

Immediate Steps to Take During a Flare

When a flare hits, the goal shifts from "push through" to "protect and settle." Your action plan:

- Pause high-impact activities. Cancel the gym session, the long walk, or heavy housework. Your joints need a break.
 - But keep moving gently. Complete rest can make joints stiffer. Gentle range-of-motion movements help prevent this.
 - Use your flare toolkit. Heat packs, ice packs, pain relief, and any flare-management plan you have discussed with your doctor.
 - Prioritise sleep. Your body heals during rest. Make sleep non-negotiable.
 - Be kind to yourself. Flares are not a personal failure. They are part of the condition.
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Medications That Help During a Flare



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What you take depends on your type of arthritis and what your GP or rheumatologist has prescribed. For OA flares: paracetamol or NSAIDs (ibuprofen, naproxen), topical NSAID gel, or a short course of stronger pain relief if prescribed. For RA flares: NSAIDs or COX-2 inhibitors, a temporary increase in corticosteroids as directed, a steroid injection into the affected joint, or a review of your DMARDs if flares become frequent. **Do not stop or change your DMARDs or biologics without medical advice.**

Rest, Ice, Heat — What Works?

Heat is best for stiff, achy joints (especially OA) — warm bath, heated wheat bag, or heat pad for 15–20 minutes. Ice is best for hot, swollen, inflamed joints (common in RA or gout) — ice pack wrapped in a tea towel for 10–15 minutes, never directly on skin. Rest is appropriate for all types during the acute phase, but avoid total bed rest. Elevate the joint if swollen. Some people find alternating heat and ice helpful — experiment gently.

Preventing Future Flares



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You cannot prevent every flare — but you can reduce how often they happen and how severe they become. **Pace yourself** — break tasks into smaller chunks, alternate activity with rest. **Stay active regularly** — strong muscles protect joints. **Maintain a healthy weight** — less load equals less joint stress. **Take medication as prescribed** — skipping doses invites trouble. **Manage stress** — stress and inflammation are linked. **Eat an anti-inflammatory diet** — a Mediterranean-style diet may help reduce background inflammation. **Track your flares** — keep a simple diary to spot patterns.

When to Contact Your GP or Rheumatologist

Contact your doctor if: the flare lasts more than two weeks without improvement, pain is severe and not responding to usual pain relief, you develop a fever alongside joint pain (could indicate infection), a single joint becomes suddenly very hot, red, and swollen (could be septic arthritis — needs urgent treatment), or you are having flares more than once per month disrupting your life.

Q&A

Question: What Is an Arthritis Flare-Up?

Short answer: A flare-up (or "flare") is a sudden, temporary worsening of your arthritis symptoms. Instead of your usual background pain, you experience a spike that may last anywhere from a few days to several weeks. Flare-ups happen in all types of arthritis, but they feel different depending on your diagnosis: Osteoarthritis (OA) flares: Often triggered by overuse or injury. Pain increases and the joint may swell. Typically settles within days to a week with

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General information only — not medical advice. Consult your GP or specialist before changing medication or starting a new programme. Emergency: 999. NHS advice: 111. Living With Arthritis · livingwitharthritis.org.uk